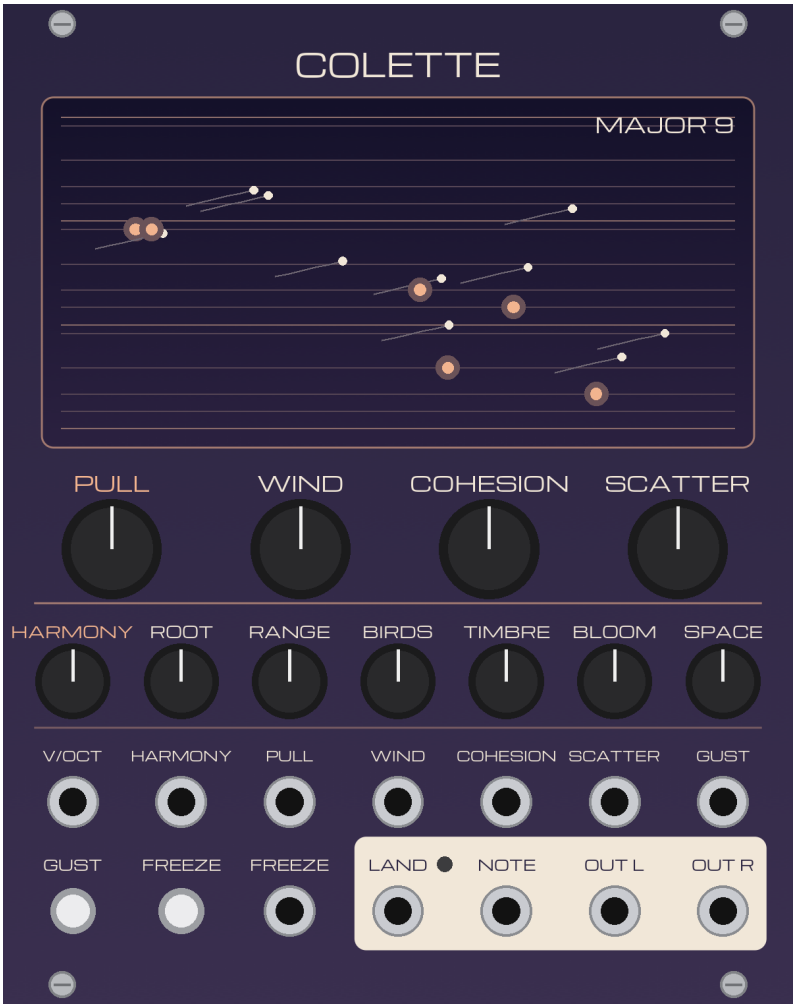
COLETTE

A murmuration of voices that settles on a chord

BASIC HUMAN TASTES

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Colette is a flock of up to 32 birds flying in pitch space. Each bird is a voice: its height is its pitch, its place from left to right is its position in the stereo field. The notes of a chord, repeated over several octaves, are perches the birds are drawn to.

A settled bird sings a pure note with a light vibrato. A bird in flight is quieter and breathier, like the sound of wings. Four forces shape the flock: PULL draws the birds to the chord, WIND stirs them up, COHESION holds them together and SCATTER keeps them apart. The chord comes apart into a cloud and forms again. Each bird that settles sends a trigger and its note.

AT A GLANCE

- 2 to 32 voices, from C2 up to 1 to 5 octaves of sky
- 9 harmonies, from fifths to the harmonic series, plus FREE
- Root changes are voice-led: each bird glides to the nearest note of the new chord
- GUST sends the whole flock up, FREEZE holds it still
- A trigger and a 1 V/oct note each time a bird settles, stereo out through a small space
- 20 HP

CONTROLS

Sky	The flock as it flies. Up is pitch, from C2 at the bottom to the top of RANGE; left to right is the stereo position. The perches (the chord notes) are thin lines. Birds in flight are cream dots with a short trail; settled birds are peach, with a halo. The harmony in use is written top right.
PULL	How strongly the birds are drawn to the chord notes and how firmly they hold on once settled. Default 55 %. Birds only settle when PULL is above 5 % and more than 1.2 times WIND. Fully right, only WIND and GUST make a settled bird leave; turning it down makes settled birds take off.
WIND	Turbulence. It pushes flying birds around and makes settled birds take off now and then: about once every 30 s per bird at the default 30 %, every 3 s at 100 %. It also widens the vibrato of settled birds and makes it irregular. Near a chord note, PULL wins over WIND as it is turned up.
COHESION	How tightly the flock holds together: each bird is drawn to the middle of the flock, in pitch and in stereo, and matches the flock's movement. Default 45 %. A settled bird more than an octave from the middle of the flock may leave to rejoin it, unless PULL is fully right.
SCATTER	How much the birds keep their distance. Flying birds push away from other flying birds less than about a semitone away, so they avoid beating unisons. Settled birds do not push, so several can land on the same note. A settled bird with a neighbour within about a semitone may leave, unless PULL is fully right. Default 40 %.
HARMONY	Which notes the birds can settle on: see the harmony table. Default MAJOR 9.
ROOT	Key of the chord, from −12 to +12 semitones, in steps of one semitone. Default 0 (C). Only the note name counts: +12 and −12 give the same chord as 0. Changing it moves the perches, and each settled bird glides to the nearest note of the new chord.
RANGE	Height of the sky, from 1 to 5 octaves above C2 (C3 to C7). Default 3 (C2 to C5). Birds bounce gently off the bottom and the top.
BIRDS	Number of voices, from 2 to 32. Default 12. New birds start flying from a random height and fade in; removed birds fade out. The overall level stays about the same whatever the number.
TIMBRE	Fully left, a pure sine. Turning right adds the 2nd and 3rd harmonics, from flute to reed. It also adds more breath to birds in flight. Default 30 %.
BLOOM	How slowly voices swell and fade, as birds settle, take off, arrive or leave: from 20 ms fully left to about 3 s fully right, 0.25 s at the default 50 %.
SPACE	A small stereo space after the voices. Fully left, dry. Turning right raises the mix (up to 65 % wet), the size and the tail. Default 50 %.
GUST	Every settled bird takes off and stays in the air for 1 to 2.5 s; flying birds get a kick. The button lights briefly.
FREEZE	Lit: the flock holds still. Every bird keeps its pitch and position and goes on sounding. A gust received while frozen is released when FREEZE is let go.

HARMONIES

CV	Harmony	Perches (with ROOT on C)
0 V	FIFTHS	C G
1 V	MAJOR	C E G
2 V	MINOR	C Eb G
3 V	SUS	C D G
4 V	MAJOR 9	C D E G B (default)
5 V	MINOR 9	C D Eb G Bb
6 V	PENTATONIC	C D E G A
7 V	WHOLE TONE	C D E F# G# A#
8 V	HARMONICS	The harmonic series of the root, starting on the root in the lowest octave: root, octave, fifth, two octaves, third and so on, up to the top of the sky. Partials such as the 7th are out of tune with the piano, as they should be.
9 V	FREE	No perches. The birds never settle and LAND stays silent.

INPUTS

V/OCT	Added to ROOT, 1 volt per octave (0 V = C). Only the note name counts, so octave jumps change nothing. Feed it a chord sequence: the birds glide to the nearest notes of each new chord.
HARMONY	Selects the harmony, 1 V per step: 0 V FIFTHS, 4 V MAJOR 9, 9 V FREE. Patched, it replaces the knob.
PULL · WIND · COHESION · SCATTER	Added to their knobs; 10 V covers the whole range.
GUST	A trigger sends the flock up, like the button. Threshold about 1 V.
FREEZE	Holds the flock still while the gate is high (above 1 V). The FREEZE light shows it too.

OUTPUTS

LAND	A 10 V, 1 ms trigger each time a bird settles. The small light next to it flashes.
NOTE	The pitch of the last bird that settled, 1 V/oct with 0 V = C4: C2 is −2 V, the top of a 5-octave sky +3 V. It holds until the next bird settles.
OUT L · OUT R	Stereo output, soft-limited to ±5 V.

HOW IT WORKS

Settling

A bird settles when it is within a quarter of a semitone of a chord note, almost still, PULL is above 5 % and more than 1.2 times WIND, and its flight time is over: 0.3 to 0.8 s after an ordinary take-off, 1 to 2.5 s after a gust. At the default PULL of 55 %, nothing settles once WIND goes past about 45 %.

Settled birds leave at random, more often as WIND rises. Below full PULL they also leave sooner when PULL is low, when they sit far from the flock (COHESION) or on a crowded note (SCATTER).

Chord changes

The birds keep their real pitch when ROOT, V/OCT or HARMONY change; the perches move under them. A settled bird whose note is no longer in the chord glides to the nearest new note without flapping: no breath, full level. Common notes stay where they are and the others move by a tone or a semitone, like good voice leading. When the glide ends, the bird settles again and sends LAND, if PULL and WIND allow it.

The sound of a bird

A settled or gliding bird sings at full level. A settled bird adds its own vibrato, 3.5 to 6.5 Hz, a few cents deep, wider with WIND. A bird in flight is quieter the faster it moves (down to 30 %) and mixes in breath: noise filtered around its pitch, stronger with speed and with TIMBRE.

PATCH IDEAS

1. A chord that breathes

The starting settings: MAJOR 9, 12 birds. Raise BLOOM to 70 % and SPACE to 60 %. The flock gathers on the chord, a bird leaves now and then and comes back.

2. Voice-led progression

A stepped sequence into V/OCT (C, F, A, G for example), PULL 80 %, WIND 10 %. On each step the birds slide to the nearest notes of the new chord.

3. Melody from the flock

LAND into the TRIG of an Ernest and NOTE into its V/OCT: every bird that settles plays its note on the drum.

4. Waves

WIND knob at 50 % and a slow ±5 V triangle LFO into the WIND input. The flock lifts off as the wind rises and settles again as it drops.

5. Lift every two bars

One pulse every two bars into GUST, PULL 80 %, WIND 10 %: the chord dissolves into a cloud and forms again. BLOOM fully right softens each landing.

6. Changing harmony

A random voltage from 0 to 7 V, stepped every few bars, into HARMONY.

SPECIFICATIONS

Width	20 HP
Voices	2 to 32
Pitch	C2 (65.4 Hz) up to C3 to C7, set by RANGE
Harmonies	10 positions, selectable by CV at 1 V per step
Levels	Audio soft-limited to ±5 V. LAND 10 V, 1 ms. NOTE 1 V/oct, C2 = −2 V. GUST and FREEZE react above about 1 V.